

TINY LIFE

A small amount of soil contains billions of tiny living creatures, called microbes. They can usually only be seen under a microscope, which is how scientists study them.

The trillions of microbes found in soil don't just sit around – they do lots of useful jobs. For example, some change nutrients into forms that plants can absorb as food. This means that the plants grow big enough for us to eat ourselves!

A teaspoon of soil contains more microbes than there are humans on the Earth.

Fungi

Algae

Microbes can be seen in large numbers as blue and green slimes on the surface of soil. These can be microscopic plants (algae), bacteria, or mixtures of both.